Crash Cart

Category: **Medical, Healthcare & First Aid** Type: **Full SOP** Priority: **High** 2 labs

Covers these lab items: Crash Card; Crash cart trolley

What it is used for

A crash cart is a mobile trolley that stores emergency medicines, airway equipment, monitoring devices, and resuscitation supplies for rapid response to medical emergencies. Proper organisation, routine checks, equipment readiness, and secure medication management help clinical teams respond quickly and safely.

Main parts

- Trolley frame and wheels allow rapid movement between care areas.
- Drawers and compartments organise emergency supplies.
- Defibrillator or monitor is stored on the cart where assigned.
- Bag-mask ventilation equipment supports emergency breathing assistance.
- Airway supplies include approved airways and related accessories.
- Emergency medicines are stored in labelled compartments according to facility policy.
- Suction equipment and related accessories are available where assigned.
- Oxygen equipment and delivery accessories are included where approved.
- Sharps container and clinical waste supplies support safe disposal.
- Checklist, seal, or lock helps track cart readiness and access.

Before you start

1. Only trained healthcare personnel should access and use crash cart equipment within their clinical roles.
2. Check the cart location, accessibility, wheel locks, drawer security, and tamper-evident seal according to facility policy.
3. Verify the documented daily or shift check and inspect for missing, expired, or damaged supplies.
4. Confirm that the defibrillator or monitor, cables, electrodes, battery, and power supply are ready for use.
5. Check bag-mask equipment, suction, oxygen supplies, and airway accessories according to the assigned checklist.
6. Verify medicine labels, expiry dates, storage conditions, and required emergency stock without delaying urgent care.
7. Ensure the cart is connected to power for charging where required and is not obstructed by other equipment.

How to use

1. Move the cart to the emergency area and lock the wheels when positioned, if appropriate.

2. Activate the emergency response system and call for the required clinical team.
3. Open the cart and organise access so the team can reach critical equipment without delay.
4. Provide emergency medicines and supplies only under the direction of authorised clinical personnel and applicable protocols.
5. Use the defibrillator or monitor according to the device instructions and current resuscitation protocol.
6. Use airway, ventilation, suction, and oxygen equipment only within the responder's training and clinical scope.
7. Monitor equipment readiness during the response and replace used supplies when safe to do so.
8. After the emergency, account for used medicines, equipment, and disposable supplies.
9. Replace used or missing items, check expiry dates, and replenish stock according to facility policy.
10. Clean and disinfect reusable cart surfaces and equipment using approved methods.
11. Complete the post-event checklist, record equipment use and medicine reconciliation, and apply a new security seal where required.
12. Return the cart to its designated accessible location and confirm readiness for the next emergency.

⚠ Safety

- Do not delay immediate life-saving care while completing routine cart checks.
- Only authorised clinical personnel should administer emergency medicines or operate specialised equipment.
- Follow current resuscitation protocols, medicine policies, and device-specific instructions.
- Check electrical cables, defibrillator pads, oxygen equipment, and suction systems for damage before use when time permits.
- Secure sharps immediately in an approved puncture-resistant container and dispose of clinical waste correctly.
- Maintain patient confidentiality and document emergency interventions according to facility requirements.

Care & storage

- Inspect the cart and critical equipment at the frequency specified by facility policy.
- Check medicines, sterile packs, batteries, electrodes, and consumables for expiry or damage.
- Clean and disinfect the trolley and reusable equipment after use and according to the infection-control schedule.
- Charge electronic equipment as required and verify that it passes its self-test.
- Report missing stock, broken seals, equipment faults, and expired items promptly.

Common mistakes to avoid

- Leaving the crash cart inaccessible, unlocked contrary to policy, or incompletely stocked.
- Failing to check defibrillator readiness, oxygen supplies, or suction function.
- Using expired supplies or administering medicines without appropriate authorisation.
- Failing to replenish, document, and reseal the cart after an emergency.

Disclaimer: This SOP is prepared from general information available on the internet. For detailed instructions, refer to the manufacturer's original manual / file.

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